

ACTION PLAN FOR CoARA COMMITMENT

June 2025

INTRODUCTION

The action plan for Vinnova's CoARA commitment is drawn up based on the commitments set in the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment¹.

ABOUT VINNOVA

Vinnova is Sweden's Innovation Agency. Our mission is to strengthen Sweden's innovation capacity and contribute to sustainable growth. Our vision is for Sweden to be an innovative force in a sustainable world, and our mission is to open and allow for innovation that makes a difference.

Vinnova is commissioned by the Ministry of Climate and Enterprise, through government regulation, to act as Sweden's innovation agency, promoting sustainable growth by supporting needs-driven research and the development of efficient innovation systems. Innovation systems refer to networks of public and private actors where innovations and new knowledge are developed, disseminated and used. As Sweden's governmental agency for system innovation, Vinnova continue to strengthen knowledge exchanges with national and international actors who develop methods for systems innovation.

Vinnova is responsible for promoting Research and Innovation that contributes to sustainable growth and societal development. The agency works from a challenge-driven perspective, working for the implementation and utilisation of research and the promotion of innovation and entrepreneurship.

The majority of the funding allocated is directed to collaborative projects. A recent example from 2024, is the initiation of five new Impact Innovation programmes², where Impact Innovation is seen as the next generation of strategic innovation programmes that focus on sustainable development and transformative transition. These programmes aim to establish powerful collaborations between business, academia, the public sector and civil society to address societal challenges.

Vinnova apply well established working methods and tools common among financiers for Research and Innovation to enable overview, evaluation and collaboration. Vinnova is

¹ [The Agreement – CoARA](#)

² [Impact Innovation – Sveriges innovationssatsning för 2030-talet](#)

developing the agency's ability to collect and use data as a strategic resource. Vinnova is implementing digital tools and work processes for transparent portfolio management.

VINNOVA'S FUNDING AND CORE PROCESS

The core process for funding includes standard systematic working methods and includes external monitoring, systems analysis, area strategies and the design and implementation of intervention portfolios. It also includes evaluation and continuous learning at the portfolio level.

DESIGN OF FUNDING SCHEMES

Decisions regarding the development and design of interventions and funding schemes are made progressively through a structured gate process. This approach enhances predictability, strengthens the ability to evaluate outcomes, clarifies the allocation of responsibilities, and improves overall quality. It also facilitates more timely and well-informed decision-making throughout the process.

TRANSPARENCY & ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

The review process, the assessment criteria and the grounds for funding decisions are described in detail and published in the guidelines and the call texts. Vinnova is currently using three main assessment criteria, with the purpose of assessing the *constellation of actors or team* that will perform the tasks and the constellation's joint and overall merits, its *feasibility* – a form of assessment that can, among other things, evaluate the realism of the project plan and how the project will be carried out. And thirdly, the *potential* of the project as a whole and its sustainability. Gender aspects are included in all three main assessment criteria.

MANDATORY USE OF EXTERNAL REVIEWERS

The consistent use of external reviewers is of utmost importance for the legitimacy of Vinnova's decisions, with well-defined quality criteria for selection and the requirement for a set minimum of external reviewers per application.

Depending on the type of call, the reviews are tasked with reading and reviewing applications and submitting their assessments in a digital platform. They are also tasked to participate in review meetings to discuss the applications and make recommendations and take active part in interviews with selected project proposals. Prior to the above tasks, external reviewers undergo training sessions specifically tailored to the relevant call.

Vinnova uses an analytical tool (QlikSense Review Pool application) to find suitable reviewers, keeping track of how many applications each reviewer have reviewed over time, and we are also investigating the possibility of using AI tools to increase the quality in the selection and also to further mitigate the risk of potential conflict of interest.

In addition to the external reviewers having the appropriate expertise, Vinnova strives to ensure a breadth of different perspectives in an assessment group. This includes balancing types of actors, gender, age and geographical spread.

CONTINUOUS DEVELOPMENT

The review processes, including application instructions and evaluation criteria are regularly reviewed and further developed through the collection of feedback and from direct interactions with various stakeholders on a national level.

EVALUATION

The object of an evaluation may be projects and programmes or major initiatives within Vinnova's area of activity. Thematic clusters of projects and actions, or other types of interventions, may also be subject to evaluation. Vinnova's evaluations are usually carried out by an independent external party that is commissioned through procurement.

There are three types of evaluation applied at Vinnova: 1) summative evaluation (shows how results relate to purpose and goal); 2) formative evaluation (based on continuous follow-up of development and results and aims at learning and development during the implementation of an intervention or process); 3) impact evaluation (aims to investigate and evaluate the effects of an intervention or equivalent).

THE PROMOTION OF OPEN SCIENCE AND OPEN ACCESS

Vinnova is to a certain extent, nationally and internationally, already active in matters related to open science and for a transition to an open science system.

INVOLVEMENT IN CoARA

Vinnova joined by signing the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA), and in December 2022 Vinnova participated in the constitutive assembly for CoARA coalition for Reforming Research Assessment.

CoARA WORKING GROUPS

Currently, representatives of Vinnova are involved in two of CoARA's working groups:

- Improving practices in the assessment of research proposals
- Towards Transformations: Transdisciplinarity, Applied/Practice-Based Research, and Impacts

NATIONAL NETWORKS

Vinnova has taken an active part in the recently established Swedish National CoARA Chapter and is engaged in two out of five working groups:

1. National research applications (*Forskningsansökningar på nationell nivå, individ- och miljöstödd*) and
5. Merit values in collaboration and utilization (*Meritvärden inom samverkan och nyttiggörande*).

The working groups have a mandate during 2025-2026.

CONTRIBUTION TO REFORMING RESEARCH ASSESSMENT AND EVALUATION PRACTICES IN ACCORDANCE TO CoARA

There are several aspects of the CoARA commitment that correspond to the mission and role of Vinnova and which are therefore considered to be highly relevant and prioritized.

The table below summarises CoARA commitments and scope and the actions planned to review and reform evaluation practices. It includes initiatives at Vinnova and initiatives financed by Vinnova. It also includes activities related to CoARA where Vinnova is involved. Vinnova has chosen to currently focus on 5 out of 10 commitments. See table 1. below.

Table 1. Summary of Vinnova commitments 2024-2027 as part of our internal and external work and contribution to the international CoARA coalition and national work.

COMMITMENTS	SCOPE	ACTIONS & INITIATIVES	STATUS
1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	Acknowledge the diversity in research careers with focus on the following concepts: Impact; External engagement; Knowledge Valorisation and entrepreneurship as a contribution to research quality. Ensure the use of assessment criteria and processes that respect not only the variety of scientific disciplines but includes the variety among different actors and stakeholders.	Develop policy and raise awareness of impact, external engagement and collaboration, knowledge valorisation. Pilot selected elements of the scope through relevant Swedish projects initiatives involving universities, holding companies, funders (SweCam³ project). Develop and pilot CV-template that acknowledge a wider set of skills in relation to assessment criteria. The CV template is to be used in future calls.	Planned and Ongoing
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	Ensure the allocation of resources for training - both internal and external.	Allocation of resources when identified need for training of reviewers - both internal and external. Review internal criteria and processes in selecting external reviewers. Broadening the reviewer pool. Promote internal competence development.	Planned and Ongoing
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Allowing for the use of regulatory sand-boxes to support research projects with a diversity of actors and to incentivise inter-, multi- and transdisciplinary project proposals.	Collect feedback regularly from reviewers and applicants.	Planned & ongoing
7. Raise awareness of CoARA and reform of research assessment reform	Act as ambassadors and inform at stakeholder meetings.	Inform externally and internally about CoARA work. Inform relevant external actors about CoARA, e.g. through KLOSSNet⁴, SNITTS⁵ and I-group	Ongoing
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	Participate in and contribute to relevant fora in Sweden and in EU.	Participate actively and contribute to the National Chapter's WG 1 & 5. Disseminate knowledge in relevant EU fora e.g. EIC policy forum, EIC, ERA Research Careers	Ongoing

³ SWE-CAM (The Swedish Career Assessment Matrix)⁴ KLOSSnet is a national leadership network for dialogue and exchange of experience around strategic collaborations. [KLOSSnet | KTH](#)⁵ SNITTS is national coalition establishing a network and an arena for knowledge sharing among stakeholders within the academic innovation eco-system. [Hem – Snitts](#)

The following aspects of the ten CoARA commitments are today common practices at Vinnova:

- The evaluation is essentially qualitative and based on expert panel review (CoARA commitment nr 2).
- Journal Impact Factors and rankings of research organisations is not part of the core process for funding and not used in practice (CoARA commitment nr 3 and 4).

Vinnova will continuously communicate general changes in the core process to applicants and reviewers as well as stakeholders. Changes as a result of CoARA commitments will be made known to relevant stakeholders. Progress made will also be included in updated versions of the CoARA Action plan. (CoARA commitment nr 9).

Vinnova is regularly subject to evaluation of our work by a third party (see EVALUATION above) to guarantee best practice, as well as to share the results of such evaluation openly. (CoARA commitment nr 10).